

DR CATHERINE (CATHY) O'BRIEN

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Research Employment History

Senior Research Fellow in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) Jan 2026 – present
Department of Computer Science, University College London (UCL)

Less than two years after starting at the Information Security Group at the Department of Computer Science I applied for, and was successfully promoted to Senior Research Fellow. I am currently working on a project funded by a Google Gift Grant: **Reimagining Privacy Harm Reporting Using Conversational User Interfaces**. This project reimagines the reporting of complex privacy harms drawing on the expertise of three practitioner communities (investigative police interviewers, university counsellors, and restorative justice facilitators) to gain insight into expert knowledge around three core reporting functions: evidence collection, emotional support, and accountability and repair.

Research Fellow in HCI Jan 2026 – July
Department of Informatics, Kings College London (KCL) 0.5 FTE

For the **Scammed by Love: Toward Mitigating AI-Facilitated Romance Scams Against Older Adults through Empirical and Cross-National Studies** project I am leading qualitative research looking to understand AI-facilitated romance scams targeting older adults through focus groups, a 13-country survey, and community workshops. Findings will inform the development of educational tools and interventions to improve scam detection, reporting, and digital safety among older adults in the US and UK. For this project I am involved in the mentorship of a PhD student (KCL) and two undergraduate student (George Mason University).

Research Fellow in HCI Apr 2024 – Dec 2025
Department of Computer Science, University College London (UCL)

I was responsible for the collection, analysis, and dissemination of qualitative research for two research projects in the Information Security Group at the Department of Computer Science, UCL.

UseCRT – Usability and User Experience of Online Content Reporting Tools

A REPHRAIN funded project evaluating the user experience and usability of user content reporting tools in the most popular social media platforms and their user-to-user messaging services; investigated within the context of online harassment as defined by the platforms themselves.

Towards a Smart Digital Forensic Advisor to Support First Responders with At-Scene Triage of Digital Evidence Across Crime Types

A UKRI funded project exploring the triage of digital devices by first responders at scene in cases of homicide and stalking and harassment, laying the foundations for the development of a smart digital forensic advisor tool that will assist with informed decision making at scene.

HIGHER EDUCATION: KEBLE COLLEGE, UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD

DPhil Cognitive and Anthropological Archaeology 2020 - 2024

Thesis title: *Potting in the Pandemic: Investigating pottery skill development and its wellbeing impacts in Covid-19 Britain.*

Summary: Using digital sensory ethnographic methods, this thesis explored how people in Covid-19 Britain used digital media, along with tools and materials typically associated with pottery, to learn pottery skills and participate in online communities following the closure of studios, and the positive and negative impacts this had on wellbeing within the wider context of the creative/digital economy.

Methods: Digital ethnography, sensory ethnography, semi-structured interviews (online), sketching.

MSc Visual, Material and Museum Anthropology (VMMA) 2019 - 2020

Awarded: Distinction.

Thesis title: *Learning a Skill in Lockdown: An Investigation into the Development of Pottery Skills and its Affective Impact in Lockdown Britain.*

Methods: Design ethnography, sensory ethnography, scaling measures, visual methods (photography, sketching, sketching elicitation, video), scaling measures.

BA Archaeology and Anthropology,

2016 - 2019

Awarded: 1st class honours.

Thesis title: *Materiality and the Mind: the impact of object handling sessions on the wellbeing of young adults.*

Methods: Design ethnography, survey, questionnaire, focus group, scaling measures.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

O'Brien C, Roslan Nuur A, Abu-Salma R, Murdoch S, Tanzer, L, Zytka D, and Warner M (**Accepted**) Harassing Harms: A Platform Grounded Framework for Understanding How Online Social Platforms Characterise Harassment. *GROUP*, 2027.

O'Brien C, Ferreira-Alturas I, Ayobi A, and Warner M (**2026**) "The chat can actually help you gauge what you're seeing": Co-Designing an LLM-Based User Reporting Tool in the Context of Ambiguous Targeted Harassment with UK Instagram Users. *NordiCHI*, 2026.

Warner M, Abreu VM, and **O'Brien C** (**2026**) Police officers are not the enemy: Applying usable security knowledge and principles to digital device triage in policing. In *A Festschrift Symposium for Professor Angela Sasse*. UCL.

O'Brien C, Roslan Nuur A, Abu-Salma R, Murdoch S, Zytka D, and Warner M (**2025**) Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms. In: Extended Abstracts of the 2025 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. Association for Computing Machinery (ACM). DOI: 10.1145/3706599.3719825

O'Brien C, Gallagher S, and Malafouris L (**2025**) Handmade Therapy: The hedonic impacts of engaging in pottery making. *Topoi*.

O'Brien C and Malafouris L (**2024**) Feeling How: MET and Embodied Cognition in the Learning of Pottery Skills. In: Nimkulrat N and Groth C (eds.) *Craft and Design Practice from an Embodied Perspective*. London: Routledge, pp.52-65.

O'Brien C (**2023a**) COVID, clay, and the digital: The role of digital media in pottery skill development during the COVID-19 pandemic in Britain. *Journal of Material Culture* 0(0): 1–16. DOI: 10.1177/13591835231212283.

O'Brien C (**2023b**) 'It's just nice not to be on screens': exploring the relationship between pottery making, eudemonic wellbeing, and Instagram. *Leisure Studies* 0(0): 1–14. DOI: 10.1080/02614367.2023.2218600.

O'Brien C (**2022**) Materiality and the Mind: The Impact of Object Handling Sessions on the Wellbeing of Young Adults. In Prezioso E and Giobbe M (eds.) *Innovative Approaches to Archaeology: Proceedings of the Graduate Archaeology At Oxford Conference 2020*. (pp. 17–27). Oxford: BAR Publishing.

PEER-REVIEWED WORKS UNDER REVIEW AND IN PREPARATION

O'Brien C, Kevala I, Asif L, Abu-Salma R, and Das S (**under review**) SoK: The AI Transformation of Romance Fraud. *GROUP Extended Abstracts*, 2027.

O'Brien C (**in preparation**) Being There in Digital Sensory Ethnographic Research. To be submitted to: *Qualitative Research or Multimodality & Society*.

NON-PEER REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

O'Brien C, Ayobi A, and Warner M (**2026**) Design Implications for LLM-Supported Consent and Control Mechanisms. In the workshop proceedings for: Moving Beyond Clicks: Rethinking Consent and User Control in the Age of AI, at the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. Available at: <https://chi26clicks.wseymour.co.uk/papers/08.pdf>

- Abreu Minero V, **O'Brien C**, Stroni A, Maclellann M, Sallavaci O, Morris S, Nic Daéid N, and Warner M (2026) Digital Triage in Policing Final Project Report.
<https://discovery.ucl.ac.uk/id/eprint/10226946/1/Digital%20Triage%20in%20Policing%20Final%20Report.pdf>
- Maclellann M, Warner M, Frumkin L, Macaulay I, Dempsey C, Kapageorgiadou V, Flowe H, Amoako E N, Hughes V, Johnston E, Nic Daéid N, Abreu Minero V, **O'Brien C**, Sallavaci O, Morris S, Stroni A, Dawson L, Behra A, Chen M, Brown K, Zouganelis G, Dawnay N (2025) Trust, Triage, and SCAnDi: Tri-Project Stakeholder Event Mid-Point Report. Available at:
<https://discovery.ucl.ac.uk/id/eprint/10206030/>
- O'Brien C**, Abreu Minero V, Maclellann M, Morris S, Nic Daéid N, Sallavaci O, and Warner M (2024) Digital Forensic Triage Project Launch Event Report. Available at:
<https://rps.ucl.ac.uk/viewobject.html?cid=1&id=2290715>
- O'Brien C** (2024) Object Handling and Well Being. *Pitt Rivers Museum Members Magazine*. Issue 112, Winter 2024. Available at:
https://prm.web.ox.ac.uk/sites/default/files/prm/documents/media/f_of_prm_no_109_issue_winter_1.15.pdf

TEACHING

Module Lead, COMP0236: Cybersafety and Online Harms (MSc, Computer Science, UCL) *Term 1, 2026-2027*

Currently redesigning the curriculum in preparation, developing a new structure, alongside new lecture notes and assessments.

Module Tutor, COMP0236: Cybersafety and Online Harms (MSc, Computer Science, UCL) *Mar/April 2026*

Acting as Module Tutor for COMP0236, leading two weeks of teaching and uploading my slides and recorded lectures to the Moodle page. One week on content moderation and user reporting comprising of: a 2-hour lecture and discussion on content moderation and user reporting mechanism, and a 2-hour workshop teaching students basic qualitative coding methodology through a practical session. And another on online harassment, bullying, and hate speech involving: a 2-hour lecture and discussion on online harassment, bullying, and hate speech, and a 2-hour workshop using co-design with the students to expose them to this method and explore the re-design of user reporting systems.

Lecturing, COMP0236: Cybersafety and Online Harms (MSc, Computer Science, UCL) *Mar 2025*

2-hour lecture and discussion on content moderation and user reporting mechanism.

2-hour workshop teaching students basic qualitative coding methodology through a practical session.

GRADUATE SUPERVISION

MSc Project Supervisor (MSc, Computer Science, UCL). *2025 - present*

In 2025, I co-supervised a student project for the MSc in Human-Computer Interaction, titled: *Co-Designing an LLM-Based User Reporting Tool in the Context of Ambiguous Targeted Harassment with UK Instagram Users*, for which they were awarded a distinction, and a substantially developed version is currently under review for publication. Currently, I am **leading the supervision of a student project for the MSc in Information Security**, on the topic of qualitative evaluation of LLM use for disclosures of online harassment experiences, developing practical guidance for promoting safer and more transparent interactions with users. And **co-supervising another student project for the MSc in Human-Computer Interaction**, looking at how restorative justice principles might be embedded into a re-imagined user reporting system through co-design workshops.

PhD Supervision and Informal Mentorship *2024 - present*

I participate in informal mentorship of PhD candidates within my research group at UCL, including one-to-one meetings to support the development of qualitative research protocols. I will be co-supervising two PhD students from October 2026.

GRANTS

Reimagining Privacy Harm Reporting Using Conversational User Interfaces, Google Gift Grant *Awarded Jan 2026*

Co-design of an AI-powered conversational reporting tool for privacy harms, exploring how large language models can enhance user experience and safety within platform reporting systems (*see Research Employment for further details*).

Role: Co-author of application and named research fellow

The Online Platform Governance Observatory, Engineering and Physical Sciences Research Council (EPSRC) *In preparation*

This project establishes a longitudinal, data-driven infrastructure to monitor and analyse shifts in digital platform governance across multiple sectors. Using co-design with stakeholders in policy, journalism, and the charity sector, it will generate periodic reports, frameworks, and tools to inform evidence-based policy, enhance transparency, and support sustainable research into online safety and governance.

Role: Co-author of application, work package lead, and named research fellow.

AWARDS AND PRIZES

Clarendon Scholarship Fund *2020 - 2023*

Awarded a prestigious Clarendon Scholarship based on outstanding academic merit and potential, covering course fees and living costs during the DPhil.

School of Anthropology & Museum Ethnography Professor David Parkin Prize in Ethnographic Materials *2021*

Awarded for the best use of detailed ethnographic materials to advance anthropological arguments in an MSc thesis.

The Keble College Durham Prize *2021*

Awarded for an outstanding performance in a taught Masters course.

Santander Award *2018*

Awarded funding to undertake a 3-week summer internship at the Pitt Rivers Museum.

INVITED TALKS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Helix Centre Seminar, Imperial College London and Royal College of Art (invited) *Dec 2025*

Title: *Being There in Digital Sensory Ethnographic Research*

Disrupting Digital seminar, Ofcom (invited) *Nov 2025*

Title: *Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms (UseCRT project).*

Informatics Industry Showcase 2025, Kings College London, London, UK *Jun 2025*

Title: *Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms (UseCRT project).*

Digital Citizens Exchange, Northumbria University, Newcastle, UK *May 2025*

Title: *Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms (UseCRT project).*

Lunchtime Lecture Series, REPHRAIN (invited) *Mar 2025*

Title: *Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms (UseCRT project).*

- The Chartered Society of Forensic Sciences Autumn Conference** Oct 2024
 Title: *A Collaborative Approach to Understanding Digital Triage and Trust in Forensic Science.*
- An Unwell World? Anthropology in a Speculative Mode, Association of Social Anthropologists Conference** Apr 2023
 Title: *Crafting the Self Online: Identity, belonging, and social connectedness in online pottery communities.*
- Visual anthropology and speculative futures, Royal Anthropological Institute Film Festival Conference** Mar 2023
 Title: *Accessing the Studio Online: Discussing Sensory Access in Video Interviews with Potters.*
 Co-chaired the panel: *Is the future of fieldwork digital? Digital ethnography beyond the pandemic.*
- Graduate Archaeology at Oxford Conference: Art in Archaeology - Production, Transmission, Reception, University of Oxford** Mar 2022
 Title: *Covid, Clay and the Digital: Investigating the role of learning resources and digital sociality in the development of pottery skills during the Covid-19 pandemic in Britain.*
- Creativity during the Covid lockdown: Life and Renewal During the Pandemic, The Royal Anthropological Institute and The Folklore Society Symposium** Oct 2021
 Title: *Covid, Clay and the Digital: Investigating the role of learning resources and digital sociality in the development of pottery skills during the Covid-19 pandemic in Britain.*
- Graduate Archaeology at Oxford Conference: Innovative Approaches to Archaeology, University of Oxford** Jan 2021
 Title: *Materiality and the Mind: the impact of object handling sessions on the wellbeing of young adults.*
- Material Engagement and Mental Health Workshop, University of Oxford (invited)** Apr 2019
 Title: *Materiality and the Mind: the impact of object handling sessions on the wellbeing of young adults.*

ENTERPRISE, EXTERNAL, AND PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

- Triage Project Stakeholder Final Event** 2025
 Participation in stakeholder engagement during the final event at the House of Lords in November, where we presented to and interacted with stakeholders such as policing officials, policy makers, and members of parliament to disseminate key findings.
- Triage Project Stakeholder Mid-Point Event** 2025
 Co-presented the project's initial findings and co-organised and facilitated the stakeholder engagement co-design activities at the event.
- Poster - Online Dating Platform Safeguards and Self-Protection: How Dating Platforms Characterise, Respond to, and Safeguard Against Harms.** 2025
 Along with academic settings, this poster has been presented at the Informatics Industry Showcase 2025, Kings College London and the REPHRAIN Research Showcase, generating invitations to speak and enabling me to network with potential stakeholders for future proposed work.
- Café Culture installation, Missing Bean Café and the School of Archaeology** 2023
 This year long research and art installation, made in collaboration with members of the School of Archaeology, communicates cognitive archaeology and anthropological research about pottery to a general audience. <https://www.arch.ox.ac.uk/cafe-culture>
- OxPods Podcast** 2023
 Interviewed for the podcast OxPods, on my DPhil research. <https://www.oxpods.co.uk/biology-1/episode/450487d3/pottery-in-the-pandemic>
- Public Engagement with Research Associate on the Talking Memory Project, Ashmolean Museum, University of Oxford** 2022
 Selected as one of five individuals to participate in this 9 month project to explore the theme of memory and investigate how museums can support wellbeing in older adults. Developed and

delivered a public engagement event integrating object-based research, interdisciplinary theory, and participatory art activities to promote social connection and reflective memory work in museum settings. Comparison of pre- and post- session scaling measures showed that participants felt the experience had positively impacted their in-the-moment wellbeing.

<https://www.torch.ox.ac.uk/event/talking-memory-workshop-june-16-0>

APPOINTMENTS AND AFFILIATIONS

Associated Research Fellow in the Gender and Tech Research Group, UCL 2026 - present

<https://www.genderandtech.net/people>

Early Career Research Associate with the School of Archaeology, University of Oxford 2025 - 2026

Public Engagement with Research Associate on the Talking Memory Project, Ashmolean Museum, University of Oxford 2022

<https://www.torch.ox.ac.uk/event/talking-memory-workshop-june-16-0>

EXTERNAL CITIZENSHIP

Peer reviewing conference submissions, journal publications, and book proposals for ACM CHI, Leisure Studies, Deviant Behaviour, Journal of Cybersecurity, and Routledge. 2023 - present

Digital Anthropology Day Workshop Participant and listed in the directory of digital anthropologists 2023 - present

INSTITUTIONAL CITIZENSHIP

Information Security Seminar Organisation Committee Member (Catering) 2026 - present

Computer Science Department Low Risk Ethics Application Reviewer 2024 - present

Graduate Archaeology at Oxford Committee Secretary 2021 - 2023

VMMA Student Representative 2019 - 2020

Institute of Social and Cultural Anthropology MSc Student Representative 2019 - 2020

London Anthropology Day and university open day student ambassador 2018 - 2023

University Archaeology and Anthropology Undergraduate Subject Representative 2017 - 2019

ADDITIONAL TRAINING COURSES UNDERTAKEN

An introduction to research supervision at UCL, UCL 2026

How to Design Trauma-Informed and Inclusive Research, Social Research Association 2025

Statistics for Researchers: Scientific method, probability and statistics, UCL 2025

Tutorial, Assessment, and Lecture Training for DPhils, University of Oxford 2021

NON-ACADEMIC PROFESSIONAL HISTORY AND INTERNSHIPS

Graduate Library Assistant, Keble College, University of Oxford 2020 –2021

Both behind the scenes and student facing, this role consisted of fulfilling book requests, re-shelving, day to day administrative tasks, adding tags to the SOLO database, facilitating ongoing use of library resources for students during the pandemic.

Laboratory Auditing and Cataloguing, Great Ormond Street Institute of Child Health, University College London 2016 -2018

Assisting in laboratory auditing and cataloguing electrical equipment, chemicals, and reagents during breaks from term.

Pitt Rivers Museum Internship, University of Oxford 2018

5-week internship working for the Collections department performing a variety of tasks including researching, documenting, adding newly acquired material to the Objects Database, assisting with research visits, photographing and packaging objects, and researching material for a blog post.

Ashmolean Museum Antiquities Department Internship, University of Oxford 2017

3-week internship in Antiquities Department, focusing on assisting with the Festival of Archaeology, store and collection management, and documentation and digitisation, gaining skills with the Museums Plus database system.

Extra-Curricular Positions Of Responsibility

Live at the Hive Committee Member, Keble College 2020 - 2021

Responsible for organizing socially-distanced live performances of music, comedy, and drama, for students during the pandemic.

Co-President of Keble Ball, Keble College 2017 - 2018

Managing a committee of 23 members, managing a budget of ~£180,000, jointly responsible for securing £18,000 in monetary sponsorship as well as in kind sponsorship, and overseeing creative direction and contract negotiations.

Keble College Arts Festival Committee, Keble College 2016 - 2018

An annual week-long festival held at my university. Marketing Officer (2016-2017), and Entertainment Officer (2017-2018).